

Can the Madman Theory Work? Nixon, Trump, and Unpredictability in Theory and Practice

Jamie Watson

This article was written before the 2026 war with Iran.

In the summer of 2025, leaked remarks from a campaign fundraiser the year before revealed then-former President Donald Trump describing a conversation he had with President Vladimir Putin of Russia while president: “With Putin I said, ‘If you go into Ukraine, I’m going to bomb the shit out of Moscow. I’m telling you I have no choice.’ And then [Putin] goes, like, ‘I don’t believe you.’ But he believed me 10%.”¹ Whether the exchange with Putin actually transpired the way Trump describes (or, indeed, transpired at all), this remark is striking for its bluntness: here was a US president threatening a foreign capital (and civilian target) with a massive bombing campaign during peacetime.

But while remarkable, this is hardly the only instance in which Trump has, seemingly offhand, suggested that he would take dramatic, unilateral military action. In 2017, Trump declared “North Korea best not make any more threats to the United States. They will be met with fire and fury like the world has never seen,” remarks that were reported at the time to be improvised.² Nor were such threats confined to his first term. On June 17, 2025, Trump wrote on Truth Social that he knew “exactly where” Iranian Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei was and that while the US was “not going to take him out (kill!), at least not for now,”

Trump’s “patience [was] wearing thin.”³ Another Truth Social post from November 1, 2025 saw Trump threaten to go “guns-a-blazing” into Nigeria in order to protect persecuted Christians: “I am hereby instructing our Department of War to prepare for possible action. If we attack, it will be fast, vicious, and sweet, just like the terrorist thugs attack our CHERISHED Christians! WARNING: THE NIGERIAN GOVERNMENT BETTER MOVE FAST!”⁴

These statements read to some commentators and analysts as dangerous and reckless, demonstrating that American foreign policy is entirely in the hands of “an emotionally overwrought, mercurial, and unpredictable leader.”⁵ But others have argued that these worries are overblown, and that Trump’s threats in office are merely an extension of campaign trail bluster that he subsequently walked back.⁶ In this telling, nobody should “read too much into Mr. Trump’s belligerent rhetoric.”⁷ Some have gone further, arguing that there is virtue to Trump’s approach and that, by being so belligerent, Trump generates bargaining leverage he can use to his advantage. The America First Policy Institute, for example, touts Trump’s “unpredictable and unconventional” foreign policy style, arguing that “this unpredictability played an important role during the [first] Trump presidency in impeding hostile actions by U.S. adversaries.”⁸ Shadi Hamid, arguing in

¹ Adam Cancryn, “Trump said he threatened to bomb Moscow if Putin attacked Ukraine, 2024 fundraiser tapes show,” *CNN*, July 8, 2025.

² Peter Baker and Choe Sang-Hun, “Trump Threatens ‘Fire and Fury’ Against North Korea if It Endangers U.S.,” *New York Times*, August 8, 2017; Jeff Zeleny, Dan Merica, and Kevin Liptak, “Trump’s ‘fire and fury’ remark was improvised but familiar,” *CNN*, August 9, 2017.

³ @realDonaldTrump. *Truth Social* post, June 17, 2025 <https://truthsocial.com/@realDonaldTrump/posts/114699610769479275>.

⁴ Anne Flaherty, “Hegseth meets with Nigerian official at Pentagon following Trump threats,” *ABC*, November 20, 2025.

⁵ Dwight Garner, “In ‘Fear,’ Bob Woodward Pulls Back the Curtain on President Trump’s ‘Crazytown,’” *New York Times*, September 5, 2025.

⁶ Leon Hadar, “No Need to Get Excited About Trump’s Rhetoric,” *Business Times*, August 16, 2017.

⁷ Ibid.

⁸ Keith Kellogg and Fred Fleitz, “America First, Russia, & Ukraine,” America First Policy Institute, April 11, 2024, <https://www.americafirstpolicyinstitute.org/america-first-russia-ukraine>.

a Washington Post column that Trump was decisive in brokering an Israel-Hamas ceasefire in early 2025, claims that “Trump is, in fact, emotionally volatile and dangerous. But being perceived as erratic and unpredictable can have benefits in crisis bargaining.”⁹ If rival geopolitical actors are unsure what might provoke Trump, the argument goes, then “defying him becomes more risky” and he will thus be able to secure more favorable outcomes in international confrontations than a meeker politician could.¹⁰

Those, like Hamid, who claim that Trump’s threats are a strategic asset usually argue that in his erratic statements he is practicing a specific approach to international politics: “Madman Theory.” As Daniel Drezner puts it, “The madman theory posits that a leader who behaves as if he could do just about anything has a better chance of persuading other global actors to make concessions they otherwise would not make.”¹¹ Instead of seeing Trump’s foreign policy as singularly erratic, those who argue that he is practicing Madman Theory place him in a broader historical and theoretical context. The name of the theory was coined by President Richard Nixon and is most often associated with his diplomatic efforts—as Drezner says, “Trump sounded different from post-Cold War presidents, but his sentiments echoed Richard Nixon, who also liked to get mad in both meanings of the word.”¹² But, as Drezner claims (and this is typical of treatments of Madman Theory), it also has “an intellectual lineage that stretches back to Niccolò Machiavelli” and is frequently associated with the work of theorists Thomas Schelling and Daniel Ellsberg.¹³ Joshua Schwartz, who argues that madman diplomacy is effective, refers to “the ‘Madman Theory’ outlined by Daniel Ellsberg and Thomas C. Schelling, and embraced by Presidents Richard Nixon and Donald Trump.”¹⁴ Notably, even (and sometimes especially) critics of President Trump’s policy link him to the Mad-

man Theory. This can take the form of arguing that the theory itself is an ineffective approach to international diplomacy or that Trump is employing it ineffectively.¹⁵

Given its centrality in the discussion of Trump’s foreign policy, an understanding of Madman Theory is critical to evaluating these arguments. It alternately functions as a defense of Trump’s brash rhetoric or a condemnation of it—in both cases, those commending Trump on his shrewd strategy as well as those charging him with dangerous recklessness insist that his record needs to be read against that of the Madman Theory. But what, precisely, is that record? How sound are the theoretical foundations of madman diplomacy, and how has such diplomacy played out in practice? Finally, how or to what extent does Trump’s foreign policy reflect the theory and practice of Madman Theory?

I proceed to answer these questions in four parts. First, I examine the theoretical underpinnings of Madman Theory, which are suggested by early nuclear strategists like Schelling and Ellsberg and elaborated by Nixon. Second, I examine how Nixon’s madman diplomacy operated in practice. Third, I compare this practical application to the theoretical articulation of Madman Theory. Fourth and finally, I bring the theory and practice of Madman Theory to bear on Trump’s recent rhetoric and actions.¹⁶

I find that the internal logic of Nixon’s Madman Theory is fundamentally unsound, caught between a belief that bellicose threats offset a position of strategic weakness and a conviction that such threats can only work in circumstances of strategic superiority. Further, Nixon’s application of the theory, primarily a “madman” nuclear alert issued in October 1969, failed to resolve these contradictions and in fact deepened them, rendering the actions ineffective. Trump’s recent rhetoric and actions, however, avoid some of the credibility and signaling problems Nixon faced, but in doing so they

www.americafirstpolicy.com/issues/america-first-russia-ukraine.

9 Shadi Hamid, “Trump’s ‘madman theory’ worked in Gaza when all else failed,” *The Washington Post*, January 16, 2025.

10 Ibid.

11 Daniel W. Drezner, “Does the Madman Theory Actually Work?” *Foreign Policy*, January 7, 2025.

12 Ibid.

13 Ibid.

14 Joshua A. Schwartz, “Madman or Mad Genius? The International Benefits and Domestic Costs of the Madman Strategy,” *Security Studies*, Vol. 32 No. 2 (May 2023), p. 271.

15 See Drezner, “Does the Madman Theory Actually Work?”; Roseanne McManus, “The Limits of the Madman Theory,” *Foreign Affairs*, January 24, 2025; Dani Nedal and Daniel Nexon, “Trump’s ‘Madman Theory’ Isn’t Strategic Unpredictability. It’s Just Crazy,” *Foreign Policy*, April 18, 2017; Keren Yarhi-Milo, “The Price of Unpredictability,” *Foreign Affairs*, October 2, 2017.

16 Todd S. Sechser and Matthew Fuhrmann, “The Madman Myth: Trump and the Bomb,” in “H-Diplo ISSF POLICY Series: America and the World—2017 and Beyond,” March 22, 2017 is a helpful piece of scholarship along these lines, but focuses exclusively on how Nixon’s madman nuclear actions may prospectively help us understand Trump’s nuclear policy (it was published only months into Trump’s first term). Madman theory, however, has been used to justify and criticize actions well beyond the scope of nuclear activity.

create a significant assurance problem. These dual shortcomings indicate that Madman Theory is deeply flawed both conceptually and practically—suggesting Trump and every other would-be madman today will face steep challenges and run significant risks trying to translate their madness into policy advantages.

Madman Theory, in Theory

Scholars and analysts writing on the Madman Theory trace its title to the same origin: a quote from H. R. Haldeman's 1978 book *The Ends of Power*. During the 1968 presidential campaign, Haldeman and Nixon had a conversation about Nixon's strategy for coercive diplomacy in Vietnam. According to Haldeman, Nixon told him

They'll believe any threat of force that Nixon makes because it's Nixon... I call it the Madman Theory, Bob. I want the North Vietnamese to believe that I've reached the point that I might do anything to stop the war. We'll just slip the word to them that 'for God's sake, you know Nixon is obsessed about Communism. We can't restrain him when he is angry—and he has his hand on the nuclear button'—and Ho Chi Minh himself will be in Paris in two days begging for peace.¹⁷

One of the striking components of contemporary discussion of the Madman Theory is that this quote is so universally treated as its complete explication. Indeed, most arguments seeking to refer to modern use of the theory omit the first sentence ("they'll believe any threat of force that Nixon makes because it's Nixon"), an elision that obscures significant meaning of the statement. From the remainder of the quote, it seems like Nixon is referring to manipulating his behavior in order to act as a madman under specific circumstances; that at some specific moment in time he might be said to have "reached the point" where he is "angry" enough about the situation in Vietnam to use the "nuclear button" and take drastic action in that sphere. But the beginning of the quote makes it clear that preexisting, consistent reputation also plays an important role in Nixon's understanding of the theory—his threats are

credible "because it's Nixon" making them.

Though this quote from Nixon is the most frequently-cited articulation of madman theory (and is the origin of the term), the idea that madness might be a virtue in international politics has a deeper intellectual history. Writing about the difficulty of making threats credible, Schelling suggests that "it does not always help to be, or to be believed to be, fully rational, cool-headed, and in control of oneself or of one's country" and that a reputation for irrationality can help credibly convey threats and even compel favorable outcomes.¹⁸ He has an evocative example to illustrate this point: "I have been told that in mental institutions there are inmates who are either very crazy or very wise, or both, who make clear to the attendants that they may slit their own veins or light their clothes on fire if they don't have their way. I understand that they sometimes have their way."¹⁹ Ellsberg similarly argues that being "convincingly mad" is a credibility and bargaining advantage for leaders.²⁰ Both Schelling and Ellsberg suggest that the perception of madness is a potential credibility enhancer and bargaining tool.

While these theorists lend some academic support to the idea of madness in diplomacy, Nixon also looked to history while constructing his theory—as Francis Gavin points out, "Nixon [and advisor Henry Kissinger] had developed this 'madman' idea based on their view of the past."²¹ Specifically, Nixon drew on two prior practitioners of international brinksmanship when formulating his theory: President Dwight Eisenhower and Soviet Premier Nikita Khrushchev. Nixon's belief in the efficacy of these leaders' policies comes down to the two distinct factors seen in the Haldeman quote: a belief on the one hand that specific strategic *circumstances* are crucial to conveying madman threats (as seen in the case of Eisenhower), and a belief on the other that a *reputation* for irrationality and madness is needed to credibly issue those threats (as seen in the case of Khrushchev).

William Burr and Jeffrey Kimball illustrate the influence of these two leaders on Nixon's Madman Theory in their book *Nixon's Nuclear Specter*. Discussing Soviet nuclear parity with the United States in 1971, Nixon tied his support for Eisenhower's aggressive "massive retaliation" nuclear policy of the 1950s to the nuclear superiority the US held at the time: he explained that

¹⁷ H. R. Haldeman with Joseph DiMona, *The Ends of Power* (New York Times Books, 1978), p. 83.

¹⁸ Thomas C. Schelling, *Arms and Influence* (Yale University Press, 1966), p. 37.

¹⁹ Ibid., pp. 37-38.

²⁰ Daniel Ellsberg, "The Political Uses of Madness," (lecture, Lowell Institute of the Boston Public Library, Boston, MA, March 26, 1959), <https://ia800102.us.archive.org/20/items/ThePoliticalUsesOfMadness/ELS005-001.pdf>.

²¹ Francis J. Gavin, *Nuclear Statecraft: History and Strategy in America's Atomic Age* (Cornell University Press, 2012), p. 115.

“brinkmanship...[or] massive retaliation” was “a viable policy... when the United States had enormous nuclear advantage,” but without that superiority “the nuclear equation does not hold.”²² Here Nixon is arguing that to issue large credible threats of the kind Eisenhower was issuing, there need to be material circumstances and actions in play—the US actually needed to have an overwhelming advantage in nuclear weaponry. However, as Burr and Kimball point out, Nixon also believed Eisenhower’s Soviet counterpart Khrushchev was able to issue credible nuclear threats and engage in brinkmanship despite Soviet nuclear inferiority.²³ The key to Khrushchev’s credibility, according to Nixon, was that he “scared the hell out of people” and convinced Western leaders that he “would have no qualms about using” his weapons “to unleash a nuclear war.”²⁴ Khrushchev’s madman threats were backed up by his reputation as a madman, despite his diminished ability to follow through on those threats.

But if these key threads are distinct, they are also contradictory. Nixon both articulated a world where material circumstances and actions were the decisive factor in credibly conveying madness, and one where playing a madman could successfully offset a lack of favorable circumstances and specific actions. These two concepts do not sit easily next to each other, but it is clear that Nixon held them both in his head simultaneously. In 1968 he again discussed his plan to end the Vietnam War, this time by analogizing to the US experience in the Korean War: “I’ll tell you how Korea was ended... Eisenhower... let the word go out diplomatically... that we would not tolerate this continual ground war of attrition. And within a matter of months, they negotiated.”²⁵ This looks like the madman quote he gave to Haldeman, emphasizing reputation and threatening disposition rather than concrete actions. But here Nixon is referring to a time where the US also had nuclear superiority that he believed to be decisive in determining the outcome of the conflict. He continued, combining these two threads, that “as far as negotiation [in Vietnam] is concerned that should be our position. We’ll be militarily strong and diplomatically strong.”²⁶

Nixon’s articulation of Madman Theory simultaneously prioritized the competing imperatives of immediate, discernible material power and long-formed reputation for instability regardless of power.

The contradiction between the primacy of circumstances or reputation is also seen in Nixon’s discussion of using nuclear weapons in Vietnam. Nixon was unclear on whether or not he would actually take actions to use nuclear weapons or merely threaten their use. Burr and Kimball quote Nixon, in a 1967 conversation with campaign speechwriter Richard Whalen, saying: “Well, if I were in there, I *would* use nuclear weapons.”²⁷ However, Whalen subsequently wrote that Nixon “explained at once that he did *not* mean that he would use them in Vietnam, only that he would be as willing as John Kennedy to threaten their use in appropriate circumstances.”²⁸ In a 1985 *Time* interview, Nixon confused the matter further. At first, he stated that he ruled out nuclear use entirely in Vietnam because the targets under consideration were civilians.²⁹ But in that same interview, Nixon mentioned putting nuclear forces on higher alert during the 1973 Yom Kippur War to send a “message” to the Soviets that the US “could not allow the Soviets to have a predominant position” in the Middle East.³⁰ Notably, this retrospective interview still displays Nixon relying on the same dual-track madman logic he articulated two decades earlier: “We did not so much want to threaten the Soviet Union with nuclear weapons as to indicate that the U.S. would resist them, conventional and nuclear.”³¹ To Nixon, sending escalated “madman” nuclear weapon alerts could send a threat (contrary to his claim that he “did not want to threaten,” he is in this case describing threatening the Soviet Union to stay out of the Middle East), but he simultaneously discounts strategic threatening of civilian populations and sees a role for “conventional and nuclear” responses.

A review of Nixon’s comments about Madman Theory thus paints a puzzling picture. On the one hand, there is repeated distinct articulation of elements of the theory from Nixon. Despite most explanations of Madman Theory relying on Nixon’s quote to Haldeman

22 William Burr and Jeffrey P. Kimball, *Nixon’s Nuclear Specter: The Secret Alert of 1969, Madman Diplomacy, and the Vietnam War* (University Press of Kansas, 2015), p. 51.

23 Ibid., p. 52.

24 Ibid.

25 Ibid., 51.

26 Ibid.

27 Ibid. Emphasis in original.

28 Ibid.

29 Roger Rosenblatt, “A Nation Coming Into Its Own,” *Time*, July 29, 1985, p. 53.

30 Ibid.

31 Ibid.

and vague allusions to Machiavelli's quote that "it is a very wise thing to simulate madness," Nixon did have clear models for his Madman Theory: the "massive retaliation" policy of Eisenhower and the nuclear threats of Khrushchev. He repeatedly stressed the same two factors he viewed as decisive for those leaders in their brinksmanship and madman diplomacy: tangible material circumstances and reputation. The problem is that these two factors cannot simultaneously be decisive—if material circumstances were necessary for Eisenhower then reputation would be insufficient; and if reputation was all Khrushchev needed then material circumstances should be irrelevant. And, as Nixon's comments on his willingness to use nuclear weapons demonstrate, he did not have a consistent answer to whether madman threats or madman actions mattered more.

This contradiction suggests that it is an exaggeration to formalize Nixon's thinking by calling it Madman Theory. It certainly suggests that the theory does not hang together as neatly as most scholars and analysts assume it does. For Burr and Kimball, even as they lay out evidence that demonstrates Nixon is thinking in contradictory ways about madman diplomacy, Madman Theory itself means something very distinct:

It consisted in threatening an adversary with the use of extreme or excessive force—force that normal people would consider disproportionate to the issues in dispute and, beyond that, senselessly dangerous because it risked a larger conflict that would also imperil the vital interests and security of the threatener. Adversaries would or might assume that the threatener was genuinely crazy—even though he was not—and therefore capable of irrational, imprudent, unpredictable acts.³²

Their definition assumes a few things that Nixon's articulation of the theory does not lay out. First, it is not concerned with the balance of power or the need to make

madman threats credible via superiority or concrete actions; instead, the "credibility of such a threat rested on [Nixon's] anger and ruthless vindictiveness."³³ But as we have seen, Nixon placed importance on material superiority and credible actions, stressing the importance of US superiority in Eisenhower's massive retaliation policy. Second, it assumes that Nixon was not actually willing or even capable of the "irrational, imprudent, unpredictable acts" he wanted to threaten; he wanted adversaries to assume he was "genuinely crazy—even though he was not."³⁴ It is far from clear, however, that Nixon never considered following through with madman threats. In private, Nixon repeatedly brought up using nuclear weapons in Vietnam. In April 1972, he told Kissinger "I'm going to destroy the goddamn country, believe me, I mean destroy it if necessary. And let me say, even the nuclear weapon if necessary."³⁵ He doubled down on this a week later, telling Kissinger "I'd rather use a nuclear bomb. Have you got that ready?"³⁶

Beyond his consideration of nuclear options, Nixon also conceived of nonnuclear options along the same madman lines—as Burr and Kimball themselves point out, "Nixon saw nonnuclear options as dramatic escalatory outbreaks that would hurt North Vietnam militarily and also send a signal with a psychological message."³⁷ Indeed, a "massive bombing campaign against North Vietnam" was Nixon's "first strategic preference," ruled out only because of domestic and bureaucratic opposition.³⁸ These were madman threats, but also ones Nixon would have been willing to follow through on.

In total, Nixon's conception of Madman Theory held a pair of contradictory impulses together. Even as it has been characterized as a straightforward strategy and linked to the logic of Schelling, it consistently contained a theoretically incompatible focus on the balance of power and a lack of clarity about whether Nixon was crazy or simply playing mad. But even if Nixon's theory contained these two competing threads, there is still the question of how the execution of madman theory reflected this contradiction. Is it possible that one of the two won out, and was effective, or that the policy in

³² Burr and Kimball, *Nixon's Nuclear Specter*, p. 52.

³³ Ibid.

³⁴ Ibid.

³⁵ Conversation Between President Nixon and his Assistant for National Security Affairs (Kissinger), April 19, 1972, U.S. Department of State, *Foreign Relations of the United States (FRUS) 1969–1976*, vol. 14, doc. 194, p. 433.

³⁶ Executive Office Building Conversation no. 332-35, Nixon and Kissinger, between 12:00 and 12:28 P.M., April 25, 1972, in Jeffrey Kimball, *The Vietnam War Files: Uncovering the Secret History of Nixon-Era Strategy* (University Press of Kansas, 2004), p. 217.

³⁷ Ibid., p. 54

³⁸ Scott Sagan and Jeremi Suri, "The Madman Nuclear Alert: Secrecy, Signaling, and Safety in October 1969," *International Security* Vol. 27, No. 4 (Spring 2003), p. 152.

practice was different from the theoretical conceptions Nixon advanced? I now turn to an examination of Nixon's "madman" October 1969 nuclear alert, and a subsequent reading of the alert against his articulation of the theory in order to understand how madman theory has operated in practice.

The "Madman" Nuclear Alert

The nuclear alert issued by the US in October 1969 lays a crucial role in contemporary discussions of the Madman Theory as the chief application of the theory. Jonathan Stevenson provides a typical gloss of the alert in the *New York Times*: "In 1969, during negotiations with North Vietnam, [Nixon] sent a squadron of 18 nuclear-armed B-52s toward Moscow and staged a worldwide nuclear readiness alert, all to appear so unbalanced that the Soviets would pressure Hanoi to give in."³⁹ For skeptics like Stevenson and Dani Nedal and Daniel Nexon, the alert was ultimately a failure of Madman Theory as "Neither Hanoi nor Moscow was ever entirely convinced by Nixon's stance."⁴⁰

Scholars who have studied this alert have generally come to the same conclusions about their effectiveness as these skeptics. Scott Sagan and Jeremi Suri, studying the planning and implementation of the October 1969 alert, argue that it "produced the worst of all worlds," as the secret alert "was both ineffective and dangerous."⁴¹ Burr and Kimball agree, writing that the October alert—and the entire Nixon strategy to issue threats in order to compel a favorable diplomatic end to the Vietnam War—eventually "failed to evoke suitable Soviet and North Vietnamese diplomatic responses" and "ended with a whimper."⁴² The main reason for this assessment is unambiguous: the alerts simply did not achieve Nixon's aim of bringing the Vietnam War to a favorably negotiated conclusion. As Burr and Kimball write, "Although Nixon and Kissinger had tried to alarm the Soviets into extracting concessions from Hanoi, they had secured little in the way of Vietnam accomplishments after months of highly secret contingency planning and White House directed measures," including threat diplomacy and the nuclear

alert.⁴³

Nixon failed to achieve his goal with the October 1969 alert because he ran into two pitfalls of threat signaling: what Samuel Seitz and Caitlin Talmadge identify as "The Signaling Problem" and "The Credibility Problem."⁴⁴ The signaling problem consists of the fact that it is difficult for leaders to clearly signal their intentions and preferences to opponents, and thus "targets often do not receive what the signaler believes to be transmitted."⁴⁵ For Nixon's nuclear alert, this problem was compounded because of his desire to maintain secrecy. Fearing domestic blowback if news of the raised alert status was made public, "Nixon thought it imperative to keep the readiness measures out of the public eye."⁴⁶ But the secrecy of these alerts meant that the US was restricted in how clearly it could signal its willingness to use nuclear force—the forces alerted were "not selected on the basis of their relevance to a potential attack on Vietnam, but rather because of their ability to escape the notice of the public and US allies."⁴⁷ As a result, the US was unclear what if any signal they had relayed to the Soviets and the North Vietnamese. A CIA Memorandum on "Possible Communist Reactions" to the readiness tests found "no reflection of acute concern by the Soviets" and "no reflection of the US military alert posture" in Soviet diplomatic activity.⁴⁸

Nixon's desire for secrecy also contributed to his credibility problem. In essence, the credibility problem is that it is hard to believably threaten an extreme or irrational action, especially in the case of nuclear weapons where such an action would invite devastating retaliation. In order to overcome this, theorists on credibility suggest that leaders must issue "costly signals," that provide clear indications of resolve. These signals can include staking your word and reputation on a visible threat to an adversary, thus risking losing face if you back down. Some theorists, like James Fearon, argue that these signals can be further strengthened by making the threats publicly and thus imposing "domestic audience costs," whereby backing down loses credibility not just abroad but

39 Jonathan Stevenson, "The Madness Behind Trump's 'Madman' Strategy," *New York Times*, October 26, 2017.

40 Nedal and Nexon, "Trump's 'Madman Theory'."

41 Sagan and Suri, "The Madman Nuclear Alert," p. 180.

42 Burr and Kimball, *Nixon's Nuclear Specter*, p. 309.

43 Ibid., p. 310.

44 Samuel Seitz and Caitlin Talmadge, "The Predictable Hazards of Unpredictability: Why Madman Behavior Doesn't Work," *The Washington Quarterly*, Vol. 43, No. 3 (Fall 2020), pp. 31-46.

45 Ibid. 33.

46 Burr and Kimball, *Nixon's Nuclear Specter*, p. 274.

47 Seitz and Talmadge, "The Predictable Hazards of Unpredictability," p. 33.

48 CIA, "Possible Communist Reactions to US Military Readiness Test," October 27, 1969, State Department MDR release.

at home.⁴⁹ But Nixon worried about precisely these costs and thus did not send the kind of costly signals that would have indicated his resolve. The fact that he was unwilling to directly threaten, either publicly or privately, robbed his threats of credibility.

Another way to possibly overcome the credibility problem is to raise the risk of accidental escalation, letting the other side know that unless they back down the situation could get out of hand without any direct action being taken. Schelling suggests that leaders can do this by introducing uncertainty of control or automaticity into their force posture, issuing a “threat that leaves something to chance.”⁵⁰ But Nixon never conceived of his nuclear alert in this way—instead, he attempted to create “an immaculate, risk-free alert operation,” thus ruling out “provocative actions or threatening moves against the Soviets” that he feared might overly alarm the Soviets or inform allies and the general public to the secret alert.⁵¹ This attempt to have it both ways and issue “risk-free” threats would thus fail to signal real resolve even if the signaling did manage to reach Soviet and North Vietnamese leadership. In sum, Nixon was not able to convey that his threats were credible for the simple reason that they did, in fact, lack credibility. The nuclear alert was clearly a bluff, and one that Nixon was unwilling to run any significant risk on. As a result, it was not signaled clearly or credibly and was ultimately ineffective.

Surprisingly, even modern day Madman Theory supporters share this general assessment of the October 1969 nuclear alert. Shadi Hamid, while arguing that Trump is productively practicing the theory, concedes that the 1969 alert “didn’t work because Soviet leaders understood, correctly, that Nixon was bluffing.”⁵² Schwartz, who argues that madman diplomacy provides “universal bargaining advantage” by making “seemingly incredible threats more credible,” nonetheless agrees that “Nixon was unable to convince the Soviets that he was truly mad, and his gambit ultimately failed.”⁵³ Schwartz specifically cites the barrier of domestic audience costs, arguing that in hiding the alerts from the American public Nixon “reduced the credibili-

ty of his threat in the Soviets’ eyes.”⁵⁴ Even those who argue for Madman Theory’s effectiveness and support Trump’s erratic rhetoric acknowledge that the alert was a failure. This is notable, since Nixon’s madman attempt in this alert is, by some proponents’ own admission, the key canonical example of Madman Theory in practice. Yet they admit that it did not yield any dividends.

Madman Theory vs Madman Practice

But if the nuclear alert represented a strategic failure, how did it reflect the Madman Theory? Does it provide a stronger theoretical logic than the one Nixon articulated, or clearly deviate from the theory in a way that subsequent practitioners could easily avoid? Sagan and Suri believe that the alert was “in accordance with his ‘madman theory’ of coercive diplomacy.”⁵⁵ Burr and Kimball agree, describing “Madman playacting” and secrecy that “conformed to the uncertainty effect inherent in the Madman Theory.”⁵⁶ But, as we know, Nixon’s Madman Theory was thoroughly split on whether a leader could issue loud threats backed up by a history of instability in order to offset a lack of military superiority (the value Nixon saw in Khrushchev’s approach) or must instead enhance threats by prioritizing tangible assets like superiority and increased readiness posture (the value Nixon saw in Eisenhower’s approach). In practice, these contradictions continue to be present—Nixon issued threats when he felt he did not have the option to proceed with a bombing campaign, but he refrained from making those threats loudly and publicly, instead insisting on their secrecy. He sought to signal by increasing his readiness posture, but demonstrated a timidity seen in his decision to keep the alert secret and refrain from any signaling that could be picked up by allies or the American public. And, in contrast to Schelling’s logic of resolve, Nixon attempted to design the nuclear alert to be a threat that left little to chance.

It is clear, then, that Nixon’s Madman Theory was as incoherent in practice as it was in theory. Rather than resolving the incompatibilities of Nixon’s madman musings, the nuclear alerts deepened them, resulting in a “worst of both worlds” execution and outcome.⁵⁷

49 James D. Fearon, “Domestic Audience Costs and the Escalation of International Disputes,” *American Political Science Review*, Vol. 88, No. 3 (September 1994), pp. 577–592;

50 Thomas C. Schelling, *The Strategy of Conflict* (Harvard University Press, 1960), pp. 187–203.

51 Sagan and Suri, “The Madman Nuclear Alert,” pp. 153.

52 Hamid, “Trump’s ‘madman theory’ worked.”

53 Schwartz, “Madman or Mad Genius?” pp. 278, 272.

54 Ibid., p. 274

55 Sagan and Suri, “The Madman Nuclear Alert,” p. 150.

56 Burr and Kimball, *Nixon’s Nuclear Specter*, pp. 292, 302.

57 Sagan and Suri, “The Madman Nuclear Alert,” p. 180.

Beyond revealing that Nixon's theory and approach were half-baked and deeply flawed, this examination also reveals that the madman concept and actions like the nuclear alert cannot be read as a continuation of existing theory about credibility. While contemporary accounts of the Madman Theory link it to the lineage of well-regarded international relations scholars like Schelling, Nixon's unclear signaling deviated from Schelling's logic—indeed, it failed to contain any consistent logic at all.

Madman Theory and Trump

The fact that Nixon's Madman Theory is constructed from a handful of remarks, contains an inherently contradictory logic, and was contradictory and ineffective in practice seems to lend support for those linking Trump to the concept to criticize his foreign policy. Certainly, those that credit Trump's approach to international relations as a successful application of the Madman Theory are legitimating their arguments by exaggerating the coherence and history of the term. Yet upon closer inspection that is not an automatic vindication for Trump's critics.

Criticisms of Trump on Madman Theory grounds often contain a curious nuance. Jonathan Stevenson, for example, argues that Trump is practicing the theory and will have predictably negative results, writing: "Madman theory is nothing new and there's a reason Mr. Trump's recent predecessors have avoided it: It doesn't work."⁵⁸ But after describing the theory and citing Nixon's nuclear alert as an example of "playing the madman," Stevenson also provides a clarification: "it's also important to remember that Nixon was not in fact a madman and chose his 'irrational' moves with precision," in contrast to the imprecision of Trump.⁵⁹ This distinction is, to Stevenson, a key weakness of Trump's—he believes that "it matters greatly that the world assumed Nixon was rational, and that many in the world harbor concerns about Mr. Trump."⁶⁰ This new critique creates a logical two-step: First, he argues that Trump is employing Nixon's flawed Madman Theory, and second, he argues that Trump is no Nixon. But if Nixon's theory is seriously flawed, then distance from it should work to Trump's benefit rather than, as Steven-

son suggests, to his detriment.

Dani Nedal and Daniel Nexon make the same argument. After writing that "Neither Hanoi nor Moscow was ever entirely convinced" by Nixon's madman actions, they continue: "But madman theory also wasn't about Trumpian unpredictability."⁶¹ They argue that Nixon's goal was to act "irrational, but consistent," and that in so doing he reduced the danger and increased the strategic logic of his madman posture, in contrast to "Trumpian unpredictability" which undermines the prospects of coercive diplomacy by acting so inconsistent that adversaries cannot be sure what US policy is.⁶² The strange argument present in Stevenson persists: Nixon's Madman Theory was an unsound policy, and simultaneously Trump's policy is unsound because it deviates from Nixon's.

Beyond the logical incongruity they display, these claims reveal a key difference in perceptions of the two presidents: proponents of these arguments view Nixon as merely playing the madman, and view Trump, in contrast, as actually mad. On this front, the skeptics sound a lot like the proponents. Hamid claims that while Nixon "wasn't actually *that* crazy," Trump is "a genuinely erratic, emotionally unstable president."⁶³ Schwartz argues that "actually being perceived as somewhat mad—unlike Nixon—is a prerequisite for the Madman Strategy to be successful."⁶⁴ But even though they are shared by critics and skeptics alike, what do we make of these claims?

With respect to the first, that Nixon was merely playing mad, the historical record seems to suggest that the claim is true. Nixon considered, but ultimately rejected, the massive bombing campaign against North Vietnam in an extended deliberative process, selecting the nuclear alert not in an erratic moment, but as the culmination of months of policy.⁶⁵ And he was highly sensitive to the need for caution when issuing his "madman" alert, watering down the readiness exercise to keep secrecy and avoid accidents. In addition to this evidence that Nixon was not privately as mad as he wished to convey publicly, the reception to his signaling also suggests adversaries saw him as acting irrationally rather than being irrational. As one former Soviet official put it, "Mr. Nixon used to exaggerate his intentions regularly. He used alerts and leaks to do this."⁶⁶

58 Stevenson, "The Madness Behind Trump's 'Madman' Strategy."

59 Ibid.

60 Ibid.

61 Nedal and Nexon, "Trump's 'Madman Theory'."

62 Ibid.

63 Hamid, "Trump's 'madman theory' worked."

64 Schwartz, "Madman or Mad Genius?," p. 279.

65 See Burr and Kimball, *Nixon's Nuclear Specter*.

66 William Burr and Jeffrey P. Kimball, "Nixon's Nuclear Ploy," *Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists*, Vol. 59, No. 1 (2003), p. 73.

While Nixon's logic and execution were deeply flawed, Nixon was attempting to put on a madman act that did not reflect his true thought process—a fact that was just as clear to adversaries at the time as it is to us today.

As for the second claim, that Trump is truly mad in a way Nixon was not, peering into Trump's mind to understand his thought process is an impossible task. But by measuring his behavior by the same metric as we measured Nixon's, one can begin to get a sense of whether Trump demonstrates greater willingness to issue and follow through on threats than Nixon did. One can take Trump's 2025 threats towards Iran as an example, and organize the inquiry with the barriers to successful madman threats that Seitz and Talmadge identify: the signaling problem and the credibility problem.⁶⁷

Seitz and Talmadge describe the difficulty of clearly signaling "extreme preferences and cost indifference," with the most fundamental problem being that "Targets often do not receive what the signaler believes to be transmitted."⁶⁸ This was the issue with Nixon's October 1969 alerts—his desire for secrecy meant his alert was not sending a clear message (if it was sending a message at all). In contrast to Nixon's quiet alert, Trump's signaling to Iran was loud and unmistakable. Posting publicly on social media that Supreme Leader Khamenei is an "easy target" is a signal that could not be lost.⁶⁹ Trump's public comments continued to directly signal a threat, and conveyed an ambiguity often cited as key to a madman approach—the day after his Truth Social post, he addressed the possibility of striking Iran's nuclear sites, telling reporters "I may do it, I may not do it. I mean nobody knows what I'm going to do." He concluded ominously that if Iran had negotiated with him sooner they "would have had a country."⁷⁰

Trump's loud and public threats also contrast with Nixon's navigation of the credibility problem. Wary of sending costly signals, Nixon designed his secret alert to be a "risk free" bluff, and due to the lack of cost it lacked demonstrated resolve and credibility.⁷¹ But Trump's repeated explicit threats sent costly signals—in addition to generating international audience costs, Trump also gen-

erated domestic audience costs by issuing his threats publicly. These threats thus demonstrated more credibility for dramatic action than Nixon's. Trump also ultimately proved his resolve in the most tangible way possible: actually ordering bombings of Iran's nuclear sites. While Nixon bowed to fears of domestic blowback in deciding against a major conventional bombing campaign in Vietnam, Trump was unmoved by his own political movement's longstanding opposition to involvement in foreign wars and undertook decisive, unilateral action in Iran.⁷²

Trump therefore appears more mad than Nixon did—and, in the process, he overcomes two hurdles to effective madman threats. This seems to suggest that critics are right to argue that Trump is convincingly crazier than Nixon, but wrong to argue that that increased irrationality removes a strength of Nixon's approach. Instead, Trump's unpredictability made his threat signaling and credibility greater than Nixon's. However, Seitz and Talmadge also identify a final pitfall facing would-be madmen: "The Assurance Problem."⁷³ The assurance problem is that for threats to be effective, they "must be paired with a credible assurance that the threat will *not* be carried out if the target complies with the associated demand."⁷⁴ Here, the madness Trump demonstrated to avoid the signaling and credibility problems makes assurance much more difficult. For one thing, his "I may do it. I may not do it" threats to Iran lacked a clear demand.⁷⁵ Indeed, Trump's comments suggested that the time for Iran to comply with demands had passed, rhetorically asking, "Why didn't you negotiate with me two weeks ago? You could have done fine."⁷⁶ By actually following through on his threat, he may have enhanced credibility, but he lost the opportunity to wield the threat of strikes as leverage. The erratic, public process Trump went through before ordering the strikes means that future assurances are likely to be hard to provide, since Iran knows Trump can change his mind and decide to attack at any given moment.

A 2017 exchange, reported on by *Axios*, helpfully illustrates the differences between Trump and Nixon. In an Oval Office conversation with senior officials and cabinet secretaries, Trump instructed his trade negotiator,

⁶⁷ Seitz and Talmadge, "The Predictable Hazards of Unpredictability," p. 33.

⁶⁸ Ibid.

⁶⁹ @realDonaldTrump. *Truth Social* post, June 17, 2025 <https://truthsocial.com/@realDonaldTrump/posts/114699610769479275>.

⁷⁰ Jake Traylor, "Trump on strike of Iranian nuclear site: 'I may do it. I may not do it.'," *Politico*, June 18, 2025.

⁷¹ Sagan and Suri, "The Madman Nuclear Alert," p. 180.

⁷² For the Make America Great Again movement's opposition to Trump's intervention in Iran, see Tal Axelrod and Alex Isenstad, "Trump's swings on Iran leave MAGA with whiplash," *Axios*, June 24, 2025.

⁷³ Seitz and Talmadge, "The Predictable Hazards of Unpredictability," p. 36.

⁷⁴ Ibid.

⁷⁵ Traylor, "Trump on strike of Iranian nuclear site."

⁷⁶ Ibid.

Robert Lighthizer, to pressure South Korea into trade concessions: “Ok, well I’ll tell the Koreans they’ve got 30 days,” Lighthizer replied.⁷⁷ “No, no, no,” Trump interjected. “That’s not how you negotiate. You don’t tell them they’ve got 30 days. You tell them, ‘This guy’s so crazy he could pull out any minute.’”⁷⁸ At first glance, this seems to almost perfectly mirror Nixon’s instruction to “just slip the word to them that... we can’t restrain him when he is angry—and he has his hand on the nuclear button”—the quote that coined the term Madman Theory.⁷⁹ But then Trump continues: “That’s what you tell them: Any minute. And by the way, I might. You guys all need to know I might. You don’t tell them 30 days. If they take 30 days they’ll stretch this out.”⁸⁰ While Nixon was attempting to play the madman by being intent on sending signals, Trump was genuinely unpredictable—even he did not know what he would be willing to do.

Conclusion

We are thus left with a grim view of the effectiveness of madman diplomacy. Madman Theory itself is based on extremely flimsy foundations—a handful of quotes that themselves contained a profound contradiction over whether madman threats compensated for strategic inferiority or were only made possible by strategic superiority. Further, Nixon’s attempted exercise of the theory did not refine its logic or eliminate its contradictions. Instead, the October 1969 nuclear alert was a mix of dangerous readiness tests and cautious hedging, reflecting the competing priorities of reputation-based threats and situation-based action. It ultimately failed to signal clearly or credibly and boiled down to an inconsequential bluff.

Trump’s madman policy falls short in another critical respect. While his brash public threats and actions appear to have some success overcoming the signaling and credibility problems, they open up a massive assurance problem. Schelling’s prescription for automaticity demonstrates how Trump’s highly personalized leadership style introduces these issues. He writes that “Sending a high-ranking military officer to Berlin, Quemoy, or Saigon in a crisis carries a suggestion that authority has been delegated to someone beyond the reach of political inhibition and bureaucratic

delays, or even of presidential responsibility, someone whose personal reactions will be in a bold military tradition.”⁸¹ The idea here is that, by insulating the decisionmaker from political leaders, their decisions will be taken seriously since they have the final say. But with Trump, such delegation is inconceivable—his frequent signaling and seesawing policy indicate that every decision is liable to change at the last minute, subject not to political processes or bureaucratic machinations but to his own whims.

The shortcomings of these two presidents’ madman policies demonstrate a fatal flaw for the madman theory: it appears to be impossible to simultaneously navigate the signaling, credibility, and assurance problems. In the case of Nixon, it proved extremely difficult to credibly signal madness while attempting to retain some semblance of caution and risk-aversion. Trump may avoid these difficulties, but only by throwing caution to the wind and embracing potentially catastrophic risks—in short, by actually being mad. He thus stands to lose out on diplomatic advantage by facing assurance problems. And beyond that, any bargaining benefits he may somehow accrue are also offset by the fact that Americans have to accept that their foreign policy is in such unstable hands.

Schelling himself anticipated this possibility. After outlining the potential benefits of irrationality and describing the bellicose displays that Khrushchev would put on, Schelling continued, “I doubt whether we want the American government to rely, for the credibility of its deterrent threat, on a corresponding ritual. We ought to get something a little less idiosyncratic for 50 billion dollars a year of defense expenditure.”⁸² Indeed, Schelling did not believe madman diplomacy was a realistic possibility for the US, since “A government that is obliged to appear responsible in its foreign policy can hardly cultivate forever the appearance of impetuosity on the most important decisions in its care.”⁸³ But even if that appearance could somehow be maintained, Schelling did not think it should be: “Khrushchev may have needed a short cut to deterrence, but the American government ought to be mature enough and rich enough to arrange a persuasive sequence of threatened responses that are not wholly a matter of guessing a president’s temper.”⁸⁴ Here he effectively

⁷⁷ Jonathan Swan, “Scoop: Trump urges staff to portray him as ‘crazy guy,’” *Axios*, October 1, 2017.

⁷⁸ Ibid.

⁷⁹ Haldeman with DiMona, *The Ends of Power*, p. 83

⁸⁰ Swan, “Trump urges staff to portray him as ‘crazy guy.’”

⁸¹ Schelling, *Arms and Influence*, p. 38.

⁸² Ibid., pp. 39-40.

⁸³ Ibid., p. 40.

⁸⁴ Ibid.

dismantles the Madman Theory that so many have subsequently attributed to him. And, as we have seen, the history of madman practice bears his concerns out. Nixon illustrated the first set of concerns, with inconsistent logic resulting in an inability to adequately signal madman appearances. Trump illustrates the latter, eschew-

ing logic and ultimately resting the fate of American foreign policy on his ever-changing temper. In both cases, Madman Theory has proved to be an unsuccessful approach to foreign policy—ineffective at best, potentially catastrophic at worst.